

# Responding to Microaggressions at Work

Reacting to the small wounding remarks, in your own way

4 psychology approaches · tips & resources — by EvaTalk

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## BEFORE YOU BEGIN

# Reacting to the small wounding remarks, in your own way

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‘You speak so well’, ‘can I touch your hair?’, ‘you’re the team’s diversity’... Microaggressions are those remarks, often ‘harmless’ to whoever says them, that constantly remind you that you’re seen as ‘other’. Repeated, they wear you down. What you feel is legitimate.

This guide validates how you feel, helps you protect your energy, and offers a repertoire of responses — to react in your own way, without carrying it alone.

### Your intention

A microaggression you hear (or have heard) at work: \_\_\_\_\_

## The 4 approaches

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This guide works your topic through 4 complementary psychology lenses. Read, do the exercises, fill the workbook — at your own pace.

**Psychodynamic** — understand the root.

**CBT** — ease the negative thoughts.

**Humanistic** — reconcile with yourself.

**Systemic** — act on your environment.

## The wear of small wounds

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A single microaggression can seem 'minor'; it's their accumulation that wears you down. Add the fatigue of having, each time, to choose between reacting and letting it go — and the doubt 'am I exaggerating?'.

Recognizing this wear means no longer blaming yourself for it.

### *Example*

*From endless 'well-meaning' remarks, Aïcha felt exhausted without being able to explain it. Naming the wear relieved her.*

### **The accumulation**

Which remarks recur? What effect does their repetition have on you?

### **The fatigue of choosing**

Write what it costs you to have, each time, to decide whether to react.

→ *It's not 'one time' — it's the accumulation that wears, and it's real.*

## The thoughts that set in

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'I should just ignore it', 'if I react, I'll seem oversensitive': these thoughts push you to minimize your own feelings and absorb everything.

Softening them gives you back the right to react.

### *Example*

*Sure she was 'overreacting', Nia realized minimizing only deepened her distress. She let herself name it.*

### **Microaggressions journal**

Note: the remark · what I told myself ('I'm exaggerating...') · my real feeling.

### **Reframe**

Turn 'I'm too sensitive' into 'my feeling is legitimate information'.

→ *My feeling is information — not an exaggeration.*

## Validating your feeling

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You have the right to be hurt by a remark, even one that 'meant well'. Your feeling matters, and restoring a fair image of yourself is an act of self-care.

You don't have to justify being affected.

### *Example*

*By no longer asking 'am I allowed to feel offended?', Léa regained trust in her own judgment.*

### **My legitimate feeling**

Write: 'I have the right to feel...' about these remarks.

### **My image, restored**

List 3 truths about you that these remarks try to erase.

→ *I have the right to be affected — my feeling is legitimate.*

## A repertoire of responses

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You don't have to address everything: choose your battles. When you want to react, a repertoire helps: from owned silence to the neutral question ('what do you mean by that?') that sends the awkwardness back to the speaker, up to a factual reframe.

Leaning on allies and documenting, if it's repeated, protects you.

### *Example*

*To 'can I touch your hair?', Fatou calmly replies 'no, and it's a question best not asked'. The awkwardness switches sides.*

### **My repertoire**

Prepare 3 responses, from lightest (neutral question) to firmest (reframe), for frequent remarks.

### **My supports**

Who can relay/support you? What to document if it repeats?

→ *I choose my battles — and I have responses ready.*

## Practical tips & advice

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### Tips & advice

- Your feeling is legitimate: you're not exaggerating.
- You don't have to react to everything — choose your battles.
- Prepare responses: from 'what do you mean by that?' to a factual reframe.
- A neutral question sends the awkwardness back to whoever said it.
- Lean on allies who relay; document if it's repeated/systemic.
- Protect your energy: you don't have to educate everyone.



# To fill in

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## Microaggressions journal

| The remark | My feeling | What I choose to do |
|------------|------------|---------------------|
|            |            |                     |
|            |            |                     |
|            |            |                     |
|            |            |                     |
|            |            |                     |

## My repertoire

| Type of remark | My ready response |
|----------------|-------------------|
|                |                   |
|                |                   |
|                |                   |
|                |                   |

## PLAN

# Your 4-week plan

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**Week 1** — Recognize the wear of accumulation.

**Week 2** — Stop minimizing my feeling.

**Week 3** — Validate my legitimate feeling.

**Week 4** — Prepare my repertoire of responses.

### Your plan in 3 lines

- What I give myself the right to feel:
- My ready response to the most frequent remark:
- The ally I lean on:

TO CLOSE

**Your feeling is legitimate — you respond in your own way, never alone.**

*Your feeling is legitimate — you respond in your own way.*

*The microaggressions you experience at work are real: this guide never minimizes how you feel. It's a coaching and psychoeducation tool, not therapy or legal advice. If you're going through a hard time, reach out to a crisis line in your country. © PerfectMatch · EvaTalk.*